Conspiracy theories

Hello everyone, and welcome to this seventh episode of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:12] I'm very happy to welcome you. It really gives me pleasure to make this new podcast for you. We're going to spend thirty minutes together, and I'm going to talk about a subject I find interesting. You know that to learn a language, the most important thing is to try to understand something. You can try to understand an article, try to understand a podcast, it doesn't matter. Every day, you need to listen to, read or watch something in French. And if you do that every day, you'll make progress. You'll understand more and more things. And I'm very happy because there are more and more listeners to this podcast. So perhaps that means these podcasts interest you. In any case, I hope they help you learn French.

[00:01:28] So what are we going to talk about today? If you listened to the previous podcast, you know that today we're going to talk about conspiracy theories. In the previous podcast, I announced today's subject, and that subject is conspiracy theories. So what is a "conspiracy"? Perhaps you don't know this word. A conspiracy is when people get together to prepare a secret project. Generally, this secret project is something fairly negative. For example, a conspiracy to seize power. We can imagine a group of people who meet, talk and prepare a plan to seize power. For example, to take control of a country, to govern it. So that is a conspiracy. And a conspiracy theory is a theory that explains an event in a way that differs somewhat from the official version. When a major event, an important event, happens, generally there's always an official version explaining it. That's normal. But alongside this official version, sometimes alternative theories emerge to explain the event. And in these alternative theories, people think the person responsible for an event isn't necessarily the person we believe it to be. I'm going to give you several examples to help you understand this idea, to help you understand conspiracy theories.

[00:04:00] The first is a theory concerning the Moon. The Moon, as you know, is that celestial body in the sky that appears only at night. During the day there's the Sun, and at night there's the Moon. Perhaps you know this quotation: "One small step for man, one giant leap for mankind." Do you know this quotation, "One small step for man, one giant leap for mankind"? Perhaps you know the English version? It was spoken on 21 July 1969 by the American astronaut Neil Armstrong when he set foot on the Moon during the Apollo 11 mission.

[00:05:14] In the context of the Cold War between the United States and the USSR, the conquest of the Moon was a very important event. The United States wanted to prove to the whole world that it was more powerful than the USSR. Going to the Moon was a way of impressing everyone on Earth. Before that, no human had walked on another planet. So the United States was the first country to send a person to another planet. But some, some people, think the United States never sent anyone to the Moon, that the Apollo 11 mission never took place. These rumours say NASA filmed the images in a film studio. And the people who believe these rumours have many arguments. They say, for example, that there are no stars in the sky in NASA's photographs. So they find that a little strange. They also say that the American flag, the flag the astronauts took with them to plant on the Moon, they say this

American flag is fluttering in the air even though there's no atmosphere on the Moon. So if there's no atmosphere, there's no wind. And if there's no wind, it's a little strange that the flag is fluttering in the photographs, isn't it? In short, these people think there are lots of suspicious, strange elements. And because of these events, they think the Apollo 11 mission never happened, that the United States never sent astronauts to the Moon. So that, you see, is a first example of a conspiracy theory.

[00:07:59] The second example I want to talk about is the Illuminati. You've probably heard this word before. It's the same in English. The Illuminati are a secret group of very powerful people, and people imagine this group wants to control the world. According to conspiracy theories, what do the Illuminati want? It's simple: they want a new world order. A new world order in which the Illuminati can control everything: politics, institutions, finance, the media and so on. They have several symbols, for example the pyramid and also the eye. Sometimes we see an eye inside a pyramid, and according to conspiracy theories, that's an Illuminati symbol. You know, we can see it on one-dollar notes in the United States. In reality, these symbols are the symbols of an organisation, but not of the Illuminati. This organisation is called Freemasonry. In France, its members are called "francs-maçons", Freemasons. The Freemasons are a real group that exists. It has existed since the eighteenth century and has participated in various historical events. For example, the Freemasons influenced the American Revolution and also the French Revolution. But the Freemasons aren't as powerful as the Illuminati theories suggest. That's a little exaggerated. In France, people are very interested in the Freemasons because they're a little mysterious. It's an official group, but a fairly secretive one. For example, it's impossible to enter this group if nobody recommends you. But that's another subject, and perhaps I'll talk about it in a future podcast if it interests you.

[00:10:48] The third conspiracy theory I want to talk about concerns France. It concerns the attacks that took place in France in 2015. You know that there were two waves of attacks in France in 2015. The first attacks were against the newspaper Charlie Hebdo, on 7 January 2015. This newspaper had published caricatures of Muhammad, and members of the Islamic State decided to attack it. They killed several journalists. Then, on 13 November, there were other attacks in Paris, in the Bataclan concert hall during an Eagles of Death Metal concert, and also around the Stade de France. These attacks killed many people at the Bataclan. There were more than 130 deaths. The Islamic State, Daesh, claimed responsibility for these attacks. But after the attacks, new theories appeared to explain the reasons for these events. These theories said the real party responsible for the attacks wasn't the Islamic State. The real party responsible was the French Government, with its President François Hollande and the intelligence services. So why would the French Government have organised this theory? Simply to strengthen its power, to strengthen police control, for example. So these conspiracy theories are similar to those concerning the September 11 attacks in the United States. You know there are many theories explaining that the September 11 attacks in the United States were organised by the American Government so it could attack Iraq, so it could wage war against Iraq. So in France, we had fairly similar conspiracy theories to explain the attacks.

[00:13:45] Now we're going to look at what all these theories have in common. What are the parallels between all these theories? What do they have in common? We're going to try to make a recipe for a conspiracy theory. You know, a recipe is, for example, a cooking recipe

for making a chocolate cake. To make a chocolate cake, we use a recipe with the different ingredients and the method for preparing this chocolate cake. So today, we're going to make the recipe for conspiracy theories.

[00:14:34] What do we need to make a conspiracy theory? First, we need an upheaval. What is an "upheaval"? Well, it's something that completely changes the established order. For example, a war. A war is a major upheaval because it completely changes the situation. When a country is at war, everything changes in that country. Nothing is as it was before. So a war is an upheaval. Upheavals can be of different kinds. I'm going to give you a few examples: they can be attacks, meaning terrorist attacks; an economic crisis; a war; a natural disaster such as a hurricane or a tsunami. An upheaval can also be a plane crash, an epidemic of disease and so on. That's the first element necessary for a conspiracy theory. There needs to be a spectacular, catastrophic, disturbing event, something that will shock the public.

[00:16:12] The second element, of course, is an official explanation. When this kind of event happens, there's always an official version explaining why it occurred. But sometimes these official explanations are a little difficult for the general public to understand. For example, if you aren't a specialist in finance and economics, it's a little difficult to understand why there's an economic crisis. You can try reading articles, but generally it remains fairly complicated to understand. But that's the official version. The official version, the explanation, is the second element, the second ingredient necessary for a conspiracy theory.

[00:17:13] The third element is that some people look for other explanations, explanations different from the official theory. Why? Because they find the official theory difficult to understand, so they want clearer, more direct explanations that are easier to understand. And generally, this explanation involves a secret group. That's the fourth ingredient of a conspiracy theory. In a conspiracy theory, there's almost always a secret group, and this group is responsible for the event. The conspiracy theory explains that this mysterious group organised the event in the shadows. "In the shadows" means "in a hidden way", "in a way invisible to the general public". This secret group has its own interests and ambitions. And it uses this event, for example, to make a lot of money or to obtain power. These secret groups want to control the world. We've already talked about the Illuminati, so that's an example of a secret group used in conspiracy theories.

[00:18:54] So with this secret group, people begin developing conspiracy theories, theories that oppose the official version and show the links, the connections between this group and the event, the catastrophe. These conspiracy theories show how these things are linked, how the secret group caused this event.

[00:19:28] And the last important thing for a conspiracy theory is its dissemination, how these theories are going to spread. In the past, we didn't really find these theories in the official media because they were considered somewhat stupid, somewhat idiotic. So in the past, conspiracy theories spread through "word of mouth". Word of mouth is simply when people spread information by talking to each other, quite simply. Word of mouth is when people talk directly to each other to pass on information. Now there's something much more effective than word of mouth, and that something, of course, is the internet. With the internet, it's very easy to spread conspiracy theories to lots of people. If you search on

YouTube, you'll find hundreds, thousands of videos explaining the different conspiracy theories. That means more and more people believe these theories and decide to share them on the internet. The internet is a fantastic tool for spreading conspiracy theories.

[00:21:10] So why are these theories difficult to disprove? "To disprove" is a verb meaning to show that something is false. For example, there's a theory, and you dismantle it, show that it's false, that this theory isn't true. So why is it difficult to disprove conspiracy theories? First, because they use many, many arguments. Each person contributes additional arguments to strengthen the conspiracy theory. When you take one argument individually, it's generally easy to show it's false. But when you mix all these arguments together, it becomes very difficult to disprove them, because there are so many arguments that you feel a little lost. What's more, these theories manage to evolve. They can adapt to criticism. For example, if there's evidence showing an argument is false, new arguments will appear. That means the theories adapt so they can remain credible. "Credible" means people believe these theories. Even if there's evidence disproving them, the people who support conspiracy theories will always find new arguments.

[00:23:07] And the last reason why it's difficult to disprove conspiracy theories is that the people supporting them ask others to prove the official version is true. They say, "If the official version is true, then prove to me that this really is the case. Prove to me that you're right." And often the official versions are so complicated that it's a little difficult to explain them, because they have very technical explanations, for example. We've already talked about that.

[00:23:58] Another important question is: why do we believe these conspiracy theories? Why are conspiracy theories so popular? Why are there more and more followers of conspiracy theories?

[00:24:19] One first explanation is that the world we live in is increasingly complex, very difficult to understand. There are many specialists, experts, and a great quantity of information. And for people like you and me, for the general public, it's sometimes fairly difficult to understand. So we feel a little lost. We can't understand the mechanisms explaining an event. And that's even more true when we face tragic events, for example attacks or natural disasters. Sometimes it's difficult for us to understand the mechanisms, to understand the reasons for these events. The French Revolution was the first event that gave rise to conspiracy theories. There were many conspiracy theories explaining the French Revolution. Why? Well, because the French Revolution was an upheaval. The French Revolution completely changed society in France. And people found it difficult to understand these changes, difficult to understand their reasons. That's why conspiracy theories appeared to try to help people understand this change, to find explanations that were a little simpler and easier to understand.

[00:26:21] And another reason is that many of these events happen by chance. For example, a natural disaster is often impossible to predict and is simply the result of chance. Now we humans don't like chance very much. Because if we believe in chance, that means we're vulnerable. We can't protect ourselves from chance. It means we too can be victims of a catastrophe, and that's very difficult to accept. With conspiracy theories, we remove, erase this chance. We explain that there's a natural order, causes, reasons. There are villains

responsible, people responsible for these catastrophes, and it's a little like a film. At the end, we understand everything, understand why things happened this way. Often, it's a somewhat Manichaean view. A "Manichaean view" means considering that there's good and evil, the good people and the villains. There's nothing in between. Everything is either white or black. There's no grey area. So that is a Manichaean view: good against evil. This Manichaean view and these conspiracy theories are rather reassuring because they help us understand.

[00:28:23] In fact, what matters isn't really the explanation, isn't really the theory. What matters is saying we've understood why. We have the answer. When we don't have an answer to a question, we feel a little stupid. But with these theories, we can feel intelligent because we have answers to every question. We can tell others that WE have understood, that we have the answer. We're more intelligent than you because you believe the official version. And the official version is false.

[00:29:16] What are the risks of conspiracy theories? We might think conspiracy theories aren't really dangerous. We might think everyone has the right to believe whichever theories they like. But the problem is that with these conspiracy theories, we trust the media and the Government less and less. We think the media and the Government lie to us, that they're dishonest, and because of that, we no longer trust them. This causes isolation because ultimately we can no longer trust anyone. We think the system is against us. And in that case, we find ourselves isolated.

[00:30:16] What can we do to combat these conspiracy theories?

[00:30:20] First, we need to give people the means to understand and express themselves. We can do that through education and school. Unfortunately, when we can't express our ideas, we feel stupid and look for simplifications. And conspiracy theories are precisely forms of simplification.

[00:30:52] Another solution is to encourage critical thinking. It's a good idea not always to accept the official version. We need to keep a critical mind and ask questions. But we also need to be able to check our sources of information, to read information and know whether it's reliable, meaning whether we can trust it or not. We need to check whether information sources are reliable, whether we can trust them.

[00:31:31] And the last thing for combating conspiracy theories is to restore trust in the system. That means restoring trust in democracy. And for that, politicians must set an example. They must be exemplary so we can trust them.

[00:32:02] That's all for today. I hope you found it interesting. Now you know everything about conspiracy theories. Of course, you can look for articles in the French media. There are many articles about conspiracy theories if you want to know more.

[00:32:28] Next week, we'll talk about stereotypes, and particularly stereotypes about French people. I think it'll be rather funny and entertaining. So join me next week for a new podcast. Thank you, everyone, thank you for listening to me, and see you soon.